Weaponized Education: Unpacking the China Scholarship Council

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State Requirements for CSC-Sponsored Scholars[1] [2] [3]

The China Scholarship Council (CSC), under the Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, provides scholarships to students pursuing academic programs abroad. However, the selection of CSC-sponsored scholars is not based solely on academic merit. **Political loyalty and ideological alignment with the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) are fundamental requirements embedded within the selection process.** Chinese universities, which act as local agents of the CSC, are responsible for vetting scholarship candidates not only for their scholarly aptitude but also for their political reliability. For instance, Sun Yat-sen University requires departments to complete a *"Political Ideology Review Form"* for each applicant, which must be signed by a Communist Party official. The university's Student Work Department—typically under the Party Committee—further reviews and approves the candidate's political and moral qualifications before forwarding nominations to the CSC.

This practice is not isolated. Institutions such as the Chinese Academy of Sciences also require a political screening that includes assessments of applicants' ***"political quality, moral character, and academic integrity."*** In many cases, a recommendation letter from the local Party committee is a mandatory part of the application package. The implication is clear: scholars must not only be academically talented but must also demonstrate loyalty to the CCP and maintain a clean political record. This dual requirement acts as a gatekeeping mechanism, ensuring that only individuals who are ideologically aligned with state narratives and priorities are granted the privilege of studying abroad on government funding.

Before departure, CSC scholars are often required to sign formal agreements or pledges committing to values that reflect Party expectations, including strict adherence to Chinese laws and avoidance of any actions that could ***"damage the interests of the country."*** While these documents may not explicitly mention a demand for loyalty, the language consistently reinforces political alignment and national service. Pre-departure orientations also include patriotic education components, where students are reminded that their foreign education should ultimately serve the motherland. The goal is to instill a sense of responsibility and duty to China that transcends the academic experience.

While abroad, CSC-sponsored students remain under close scrutiny. **Regulations stipulate that they must regularly submit status reports to their respective Chinese embassies or consulates, typically every six months.** These updates include information about academic progress, employment status (if applicable), and political viewpoints. Additionally, students are required to obtain prior approval from Chinese authorities before making any changes to their academic program or host institution—reinforcing the perception that scholars are under continuous state oversight even while residing overseas.

Behavior deemed politically deviant or disruptive—such as participating in human rights protests or publicly criticizing the Chinese government—can lead to termination of funding or formal reprimand. **CSC guidelines vaguely warn against *"activities unrelated to one's studies that seriously affect academic progress"* or *"extremely bad behavior,"*** leaving wide latitude for interpretation and enforcement. These

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1 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/chuguo
2 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/chuguo/s/2408
3 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/uploads/%A1%B6%B9%FA%BC%D2%C1%F4%D1%A7%BB%F9%BD%F0%B9%DC%C0%ED%CE%AF%D4%B1%BB%E1%B3%F6%B9%FA%C1%F4%D1%A7%C8%CB%D4%B1%D0%EB%D6%AA%A1%B72012%C4%EA%B0%E6.pdf or https://sweden.lxgz.org.cn/Portals/16/images/%E6%8A%A5%E5%88%B0%E9%A1%BB%E7%9F%A5%E5%8F%8A%E5%9B%BD%E5%A4%96%E7%AE%A1%E7%90%86%E6%B3%A8%E6%84%8F%E4%BA%8B%E9%A1%B9.doc

stipulations create a chilling effect on student speech and behavior, effectively discouraging any dissent during their time abroad.

Upon completion of their studies, CSC scholars are required to return to China and serve a minimum of two years in a field relevant to their training. This ***"service obligation"*** is a core component of the CSC program, intended to ensure that foreign-acquired knowledge is reinvested into China's domestic development. Returnees must report both to the CSC and their home institution and may also face political debriefings or reintegration evaluations. In cases involving CCP members, their Party branch must assess their ideological performance abroad, often requiring a detailed ***"thought report"*** **(思想汇报)** documenting their loyalty and reflections while overseas.

The entire lifecycle of a CSC scholarship—from initial selection, to study abroad, to post-return service—is framed by mechanisms that maintain ideological control and political conformity. U.S. institutions hosting CSC-sponsored students should be aware that these individuals operate within an extended system of Party-state oversight and are subject to reporting structures that can influence their behavior, research choices, and communications. These practices raise important considerations for institutional transparency, academic freedom, and research security.

Reporting Requirements and Monitoring Mechanisms

Regular Reporting to Chinese Authorities

A defining feature of CSC scholarships is the obligation for recipients to continually report their status and progress during their time overseas. **Upon arriving in the host country, scholars must register with the local Chinese embassy or consulate within 10 days.** This initial registration begins the formal oversight relationship between the scholar and the Chinese government. Throughout their time abroad, CSC scholars are required to submit scheduled reports at frequent intervals. According to official guidelines, visiting scholars, senior researchers, and postdoctoral fellows must submit quarterly reports, while degree-seeking students (e.g., Master's and PhD students) are required to report each semester.[4]

The standard reporting form, titled the ***Study/Research Report*** **(学习/研修情况报告表),** must be completed regularly and signed by the student's overseas academic advisor, attesting to academic progress, research activities, publications, coursework, and overall performance. These reports are then submitted to the Education Office at the local Chinese embassy or consulate, where education officers add their own remarks and forward them to CSC headquarters in Beijing. Regulations stipulate that embassy **officials must "designate specific personnel to establish contact with the student's advisor or research collaborator, to stay informed at all times about the student's study and work situation"**.[5] This two-tier reporting structure—embassy to CSC—ensures that Chinese authorities maintain close and continuous oversight of their students abroad.

In addition to reporting to embassies, CSC scholars often must update their *"sending institutions"* in China—usually the university or research organization that nominated them for CSC funding. For example, joint-training PhD students are expected to send their progress reports both to their host university (via the embassy) and their home institution and Chinese advisor. This multilayered oversight

4 Ibid.
5 Ibid.

ensures that the CSC, the embassy, and the domestic institution all have visibility into the scholar's development.

"Thought Reports" and Ideological Monitoring

Beyond academic performance, ideological loyalty is also monitored—especially for CCP members. While abroad, Party members are either assigned to a temporary CCP branch (often organized by the embassy) or kept on file as *"unaffiliated"* members with their home organization. These Party members are expected to submit periodic *思想汇报* **("thought reports")** to their Party organization, reflecting on their ideological discipline, political loyalty, and moral character while living in a foreign environment. According to a CCP-affiliated Q&A portal, "there is no fixed rule on frequency, but generally a Party member abroad should write an ideological report at least every six months".[6]

Upon returning to China, Party members must submit a final ideological report and formally apply to resume participation in Party organization life. Their behavior abroad is reviewed to determine whether they remained ideologically faithful, avoided any anti-China activities, and refrained from applying for foreign residency or citizenship without approval. This procedure ensures continued Party control and ideological alignment.

Even for non-Party students, ideological guidance is subtly reinforced. Chinese embassies abroad often organize political education sessions for all CSC-funded students, under programs such as ***"Safe Study Abroad"*** **(平安留学)**, where officials discuss patriotism, Chinese laws (like the National Security Law), and the importance of representing the country well.[7] Attendance at such events, while nominally voluntary, is expected of government-funded students.[8]

Monitoring of Academic Progress and Performance

CSC doesn't just receive reports—it actively assesses students' progress through structured performance reviews. For instance, all PhD students are subject to an annual review process (*年度复核*) in which they must submit progress reports through the CSC online portal, including evaluation letters from their foreign supervisors. These reviews determine whether the student will continue receiving funding.[9]

If a scholar fails to make sufficient progress or receives negative feedback, CSC may reduce or cancel their funding. Embassies are also empowered to impose sanctions. For example, if a scholar fails to report to the embassy within 10 days of arrival or neglects to submit reports on time, they can be issued a warning. Continued delay can result in suspension of stipends or even revocation of CSC funding status.[10]

The consequences of noncompliance are not symbolic. If a student goes six months without submitting required reports, CSC classifies them as in breach of their scholarship agreement. These penalties are

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6 See https://wenda.12371.cn/liebiao.php?mod=viewthread&tid=628902

*7 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/uploads/《**国家留学基金**资助出国留学人员须知》2012**年版**.pdf*

8 See https://www.cscse.edu.cn/cscse/sy/xwdt/2024052914251715493/index.html

9 Ibid.

10 Ibid.

codified in the official CSC contract, which states that "failure to submit study reports or to attend the annual progress review" constitutes a contract violation.[11]

Contractual Obligations of CSC Scholarship Recipients

All recipients of the CSC award are bound by a legally enforceable tripartite contract—between the scholar (Party B), the CSC (Party A, representing the Chinese state), and a financial guarantor (Party C). [12] This agreement, referred to as the ***"Agreement to Sponsor Study Abroad"* (资助出国留学协议书)**, is required prior to departure and typically notarized[13]. It stipulates the scholar's obligations and the conditions under which government sponsorship is provided, including the use of a security deposit or a co-signed guarantor to ensure compliance. The fundamental principle is **"签约派出，违约赔偿"—no dispatch without a signed contract, and damages for any breach.**[14]

At the heart of the agreement is the mandatory return and service clause. Scholars must return to China within a specified time after completing their studies (usually within one month) and are required to serve domestically for at least two years.[15] This clause is non-negotiable and presented as a patriotic repayment for state investment.[16] Failure to return in time results in penalties: a delay of up to three months is treated as a partial breach, triggering a 20% repayment penalty on top of the full scholarship amount. Delays longer than three months or complete failure to return are classified as full breaches and invoke harsher consequences, including a 30% penalty and public blacklisting.[17] The guarantor is held jointly liable, which creates familial and financial pressure to ensure compliance.[18]

The contract also strictly regulates scholars' conduct during their overseas period. Scholars are prohibited from altering their study plan, changing universities, switching countries, or extending their stay without prior CSC approval.[19] Unauthorized deviations are deemed breaches. Even temporary academic collaborations in a third country—lasting over one month—can void the contract.[20] Engaging in unrelated work, entrepreneurship, or early withdrawal from the program without permission is also prohibited.[21] These rules ensure that scholars focus exclusively on their sanctioned academic mission.

Importantly, the contract includes clauses emphasizing state loyalty and secrecy. Scholars, particularly those in sensitive fields, may be required to sign additional confidentiality pledges and are explicitly warned against leaking information.[22] Scholars are also obligated to uphold the dignity of the Chinese state and avoid behavior that may damage national interests.[23] These ideological provisions, while broad, signal the dual academic-political expectations placed on CSC scholars.

In the event of a contract violation, the CSC initiates a structured enforcement process. The scholar and their guarantor receive formal notices demanding repayment within a set timeline.[24] If unresolved, the

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11 Ibid.
12 See https://www.sdxz2050.com/36475.html
13 Ibid.
14 Ibid.
15 See https://www.hnagri.org.cn/rjc/article-13258.html
16 Ibid.
17 See https://gs.tongji.edu.cn/info/1076/3688.htm
18 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/uploads/国家留学基金管理办法2012年版.pdf
19 See https://szmed.sysu.edu.cn/zh-hans/article/3180
20 Ibid.
21 Ibid.
22 See https://wenda.12371.cn/liebiao.php?mod=viewthread&tid=628902
23 Ibid.
24 See https://gjjlc.xtu.edu.cn/info/1011/1891.htm

CSC may confiscate deposits, initiate civil litigation in China, and leverage diplomatic channels abroad. These measures include notifying host institutions of the breach, publicizing the violator's name domestically, and advising Chinese institutions not to hire them in the future.[25] Such enforcement ensures long-term career consequences and reputational damage.[26]

Lastly, CSC scholars must credit their sponsorship in all publications and academic outputs, using standardized acknowledgments.[27] This ensures the CSC—and the Chinese government—receive recognition for the funded research and allows authorities to track intellectual contributions made under state sponsorship.

In essence, CSC-funded scholars operate under a binding contract that controls their movement, research activity, and post-graduation trajectory. This legal framework ensures they remain loyal to China's interests throughout their academic careers abroad and are ultimately reintegrated into China's talent pipeline upon completion of their studies.[28]

CSC Institutional Partnerships and Compliance

CSC MOUs with U.S. Universities

The CSC has formal Memoranda of Understanding (MOUs) with several American universities to jointly fund Chinese students. According to an official notice, seven U.S. institutions had active CSC partnership scholarships in 2025: **University of California, Irvine (UCI)**; **UC Davis**; **UC Riverside**; **Dartmouth College**; **University of Notre Dame**; **Temple University**; and **University of Tennessee**[29]. These MOUs enable up to 240 Chinese students in 2025 to pursue Master's or PhD studies (or joint doctoral research) at those universities with shared funding support.[30] Under such agreements, the host university typically waives tuition (and may provide other support), while CSC provides the student's living stipend, travel, and related expenses. The arrangement is mutually beneficial: China secures training for its students at top universities, and the universities gain talented graduate students whose primary financial support (stipend and fees) comes from the CSC. Many of these partnerships are advertised on university websites, emphasizing that Chinese applicants with CSC funding are welcome and may receive admissions preference or guaranteed slots.

Confirmed U.S. Partnerships (2025):[31]

- **University of California, Irvine** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.
- **UC Davis** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.
- **UC Riverside** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.
- **Dartmouth College** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.
- **University of Notre Dame** – MOU with CSC for PhD scholarships (detailed below).
- **Temple University** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.
- **University of Tennessee** – MOU with CSC for graduate scholarships.

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25 Ibid.
26 Ibid.
27 See https://gjjlc.xtu.edu.cn/info/1011/1891.htm
28 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/
29 See https://gs.tongji.edu.cn/info/1076/3688.htm
30 Ibid.
31 Ibid.

Each of these was listed in Chinese university notices as partner schools in the **2025 CSC scholarship programs**.[32] For example, Tongji University's graduate school notice explicitly states that *"in accordance with MOUs signed between CSC and the above 7 schools, 2025 will fund up to 240 outstanding Chinese youths to pursue master's or doctoral degrees at those American universities."*.[33] This confirms the existence of the MOUs with those institutions and the scale of the program.

Joint PhD Scholarship Program: CSC–Notre Dame

One prominent partnership is between CSC and the **University of Notre Dame**. In 2022, Notre Dame and CSC signed a cooperation agreement to jointly fund Chinese doctoral students at Notre Dame. Under this **CSC–Notre Dame Joint PhD Scholarship** program, up to **40** Chinese PhD students can be admitted to Notre Dame each year on full scholarships.[34] The division of financial responsibilities is clearly defined:

- **CSC's support:** CSC provides each student with up to 48 months (4 years) of living stipend at Chinese-government standard rates (this includes health insurance), plus one round-trip international airfare and visa application fees.[35] In other words, CSC fully covers the student's living expenses for the first four years of the PhD program.[36]
- **Notre Dame's support:** Notre Dame commits to waiving **100% of tuition** for the student's PhD study. The university typically does this by treating the student like any other funded PhD student (e.g. through teaching or research assistantships or internal scholarships).[37] The tuition waiver covers up to 48 months of study. Additionally, Notre Dame will provide funding for the **fifth year** of the PhD if needed – this includes the required tuition and a stipend for that year.[38] Essentially, Notre Dame guarantees up to 4 years of tuition scholarship and will cover the 5th year's tuition and living costs if the student requires a fifth year to complete the PhD.[39] (Most PhD programs at ND are designed for 5 years; Notre Dame ensures the CSC scholars are supported through completion.)

This arrangement means the student's tuition is paid by Notre Dame, and their living costs by CSC, for the normal duration of the doctoral program. The students must still meet Notre Dame's admission standards and any English language requirements. Notably, Notre Dame's graduate school and international office publicize this opportunity. As of 2023, it was advertised that **40 scholarships per year** are available for Chinese PhD applicants in any field at Notre Dame.[40] The selection process involves the student first securing nomination for the CSC scholarship (without needing an admission letter at that stage) and then applying to Notre Dame, with final admission offers coordinated so that CSC-funded candidates are admitted in line with the quota.[41] The **funding model** (CSC stipend + university tuition scholarship) is representative of many CSC-university partnerships.

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32 Ibid.
33 Ibid.
34 See https://oiec.zit.edu.cn/info/1146/1046.htm
35 See https://ge.lzu.edu.cn/guojijiaoliu/gongpaixiangmu/2022/1017/205981.html
36 Ibid.
37 Ibid.
38 Ibid.
39 Ibid.
40 See https://oiec.zit.edu.cn/info/1146/1046.htm
41 Ibid.

Verification: A Lanzhou University notice about the 2023 CSC–Notre Dame program confirms *"40 Chinese outstanding youth will be selected and funded to go to Notre Dame for PhD degrees"*[42] and details the funding split: CSC provides the living allowance (up to 48 months) and travel, while *"Notre Dame will provide all tuition for the first 48 months via scholarships (assistantships) and will cover the fifth year's tuition and stipend needed to complete the degree"*.[43] This matches the description above, evidencing the joint funding agreement. The program covers all disciplines and was set to continue in 2024 and 2025 with similar terms.[44]

CSC–University of Tulsa Partnership and Funding

Another example of a U.S. partnership is with **The University of Tulsa** (Oklahoma). CSC and the University of Tulsa launched a cooperative scholarship program (for master's and PhD students), which by 2025 offered up to **40 spots per year**.[45] The breakdown for Tulsa's program is roughly: **20 master's students** and **20 doctoral students** annually (the doctoral category often split into some full PhDs and some joint PhD research students).[46] A CSC notice for 2025 confirms the total "not exceeding 40 per year" for Tulsa.[47]

The funding arrangement for the CSC–Tulsa scholarship mirrors the model of shared contributions:

- **CSC provides:** For each student, CSC will cover up to 48 months of living stipend (per Chinese government stipend standards) for doctoral students, and up to 24 months of stipend for master's students, along with one round-trip airfare and visa fees. Notably, because Tulsa's agreement includes partial tuition waivers for master's students, CSC also will pay **50% of the tuition** for up to 2 years for those master's students (to complement Tulsa's tuition scholarship). For joint PhD students (those visiting Tulsa for part of their doctoral research), CSC provides up to 24 months of stipend and travel as needed.[48]
- **University of Tulsa provides:** Tulsa agrees to **waive 100% of tuition for up to 48 months** (4 years) for CSC-funded PhD students. Additionally, if a PhD student remains in good academic standing and needs more time, Tulsa will provide up to **three years of living expenses starting from the 5th year onward**. [49] (This is a notable commitment: it means if a PhD extends beyond 4 years, Tulsa will fund the stipend for year 5 and potentially up to year 7, ensuring the student can finish without CSC support.) For **Master's students**, Tulsa offers a **50% tuition waiver** each year for up to 2 years of the master's program. For **joint-training PhD scholars** (visiting researchers), Tulsa provides the necessary research facilities, office/lab space, and library access, since those students remain enrolled at their Chinese university.[50]

This partnership effectively shares the cost: Tulsa shoulders full (or half) tuition costs and even some stipend in later years, while CSC pays the students' stipend (and half tuition for masters) in the early years.[51] The goal is to make the studies fully funded without burdening the student.

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42 See https://ge.lzu.edu.cn/guojijiaoliu/gongpaixiangmu/2022/1017/205981.html
43 Ibid.
44 See https://oir.whu.edu.cn/info/1191/8231.htm
45 See https://seugs.seu.edu.cn/2024/0821/c28944a500317/page.htm
46 Ibid.
47 See https://www.hactcm.edu.cn/info/1024/113294.htm
48 See https://grs.cup.edu.cn/E3001/91058.jhtml
49 See https://grs.cup.edu.cn/E3001/91058.jhtml
50 Ibid.
51 Ibid.

Sources: The cooperation is documented on the CSC website and Chinese university portals. For instance, China University of Petroleum (Beijing) issued a notice detailing the **2025 CSC–Tulsa scholarship**: it explicitly states *"according to the MOU with The University of Tulsa… in 2025 outstanding Chinese youth will be jointly funded to pursue degrees or joint PhD research at Tulsa"*.[52] It then specifies under "Funding Contents" the points above: CSC's coverage of stipend (48 months for PhD, etc.) and Tulsa's waiver of tuition (4 years for PhD) plus additional support beyond year 4, as well as the 50% tuition waivers for masters.[53] This confirms the robust funding package for CSC scholars at Tulsa. The program launched in 2024 and continued into 2025, with application instructions disseminated at various Chinese universities by fall 2024.[54]

Additional U.S. Partnerships: Besides the seven major U.S. partners for 2025 and the Tulsa program, CSC occasionally adds new partner universities. For example, in 2024–2025 CSC also initiated a scholarship partnership with **Saint Joseph's University** (Philadelphia), though at a smaller scale (reportedly 20 slots per year, focused on masters)[55] [56]. These partnerships indicate CSC's expanding network beyond large research universities, to provide opportunities across a range of U.S. institutions.

Canadian University Partnerships with CSC

CSC has also established joint funding agreements with universities in **Canada**. Canadian institutions such as **Dalhousie University**, the **University of Toronto**, and the **University of Alberta** have been participants in CSC scholarship programs:

- **Dalhousie University:** Dalhousie is a long-standing partner for CSC scholarships, with *"over a decade of experience supporting students funded through the CSC program"*. Dalhousie is considered a "preferred host" for CSC scholars. Each year, up to **20 new PhD students** from China can receive CSC scholarships to attend Dalhousie. CSC provides up to four years of funding (stipend, etc.) for those students, and in parallel *"each student's Dalhousie supervisor will provide funding to cover tuition and fees"* for those four years. In practice, this means Dalhousie waives the tuition (often through faculty research grants or internal scholarships) for CSC-backed PhD students, while CSC pays their living costs. The Dalhousie Faculty of Graduate Studies openly advertises this, noting the March application cycle and that the scholarship covers *"tuition, airfare and living allowance for up to 4 years"* for the student. This confirms an active MOU where costs are shared.[57] [58] [59]

- **University of Toronto:** The University of Toronto has likewise been involved in CSC programs. While specific figures from official sources are harder to find, the Times Higher Education reported that UofT is among universities around the world with CSC partnerships. Generally, UofT and other large Canadian universities offer admission and tuition support to CSC scholars. (For example, a Chinese media report noted that the CSC funds many students at UofT and

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52 Ibid.
53 Ibid.
54 See https://www.hactcm.edu.cn/info/1024/113294.htm
55 Ibid.
56 See https://seugs.seu.edu.cn/2024/0821/c28944a500317/page.htm
57 See https://www.dal.ca/faculty/gradstudies/finance-your-studies/scholarships-bursaries/csc-phd.html#:~:text=The%20Chinese%20Scholarship%20Council%20,funded%20through%20the%20CSC%20program
58 See https://www.dal.ca/faculty/gradstudies/finance-your-studies/scholarships-bursaries/csc-phd.html#:~:text=CSC%20provides%20up%20to%20four,cover%20tuition%20%26%20incidental%20fees
59 See https://www.dal.ca/faculty/gradstudies/finance-your-studies/scholarships-bursaries/csc-phd.html#:~:text=Deadline%3A%20March%20of%20each%20year,Doctoral%20Available%20to%3A%20International%20students

other top Canadian schools each year, implying agreements in place similar to those in the US/UK.) Although exact numbers are not cited in our sources, UofT's inclusion in CSC's list of partner universities suggests a formal understanding.[60] [61]

- **University of Alberta:** The University of Alberta explicitly outlines a process for CSC applicants, indicating a formal partnership. UAlberta's graduate admissions site instructs prospective CSC-funded PhD students that if admitted, their admission offer letter will state that ***"if the student receives a CSC scholarship, the University of Alberta will provide scholarship funding to cover their tuition fees for the first four years of the PhD program."***.[62] In other words, UAlberta guarantees a **tuition waiver for 4 years** for CSC-sponsored PhD students. This is only done for students who indicate they are applying for the CSC scholarship. The UAlberta faculty must inform the Faculty of Graduate Studies to include that clause in the offer letter.[63] This practice reflects an MOU: it formalizes that UAlberta will not charge tuition to CSC PhDs (for the standard duration), aligning with CSC's 4-year funding period for stipends. Additionally, University of Alberta has collaborated with Chinese institutions (like Tsinghua University) in context of CSC programs and research exchanges[64], further indicating active engagement.

- **Other Canadian Universities:** CSC runs a **"Canada-China Scholars' Exchange Program"** and other schemes that list many Canadian universities. For example, the CSC's 2025 project guidelines for Canada (as referenced on the CSC site) include partnerships with the **University of Alberta**, **Dalhousie University**, **University of Regina**, **University of Manitoba**, etc.[65] This suggests multiple MOUs in Canada, often similar in structure: the Canadian university waives tuition or provides a scholarship, and CSC provides the student's stipend and travel. The University of Toronto and others likely follow this pattern (though details on each are typically published in program guidelines rather than press releases).

In summary, Canadian universities actively participate in CSC agreements. Dalhousie's program (20 PhDs/year with full funding) is a concrete example[66], and University of Alberta's policy of covering tuition for CSC scholars for 4 years demonstrates these agreements in action.[67] These arrangements help Canadian schools attract excellent Chinese students with external funding, similar to the U.S. and U.K. models.

CSC Partnerships in the UK (e.g. Oxford & Cambridge)

The United Kingdom has a well-established set of CSC partnerships, especially with its leading universities. The **University of Cambridge** and **University of Oxford** in particular have longstanding joint scholarship programs with the CSC:

- **University of Cambridge:** Cambridge, through the **Cambridge Trust**, has been collaborating with the CSC for many years. The Cambridge Trust's official site confirms that *"The China Scholarship*

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60 See https://www.timeshighereducation.com/student/advice/scholarships-chinese-students-looking-study-abroad#:~:text=abroad%20www,Han%20Kun%20Youth%20Legal
61 See https://www.globaladmissions.com/blog/phd-scholarships-for-international-students-in-canada#:~:text=7%20Amazing%20PhD%20Scholarships%20for,CSC%29%20offers%20scholarships
62 See https://www.ualberta.ca/en/admissions-programs/sponsored-student-program/csc-information-for-prospective-students.html
63 Ibid.
64 See https://www.tsinghua.edu.cn/en/info/1245/4168.htm
65 See https://www.csc.edu.cn/article/3622
66 See https://www.dal.ca/faculty/gradstudies/finance-your-studies/scholarships-bursaries/csc-phd.html
67 See https://www.ualberta.ca/en/admissions-programs/sponsored-student-program/csc-information-for-prospective-students.html

Council works with the Cambridge Trust to offer both the CSC Cambridge Scholarship (for PhD applicants) and the CSC Cambridge Masters Scholarship, in a range of academic subjects.".[68] These scholarships cover **University of Cambridge tuition fees** and provide an annual stipend for living costs, plus a travel allowance.[69] Essentially, CSC and Cambridge co-fund the students: Cambridge (via the Trust) covers the tuition and perhaps part of the stipend, while CSC provides a stipend and travel. The program is quite large; Cambridge doesn't publicly state a fixed number of awards on that page, but external analyses have noted that Cambridge admits dozens of CSC-funded PhD students each year. According to a UK Parliamentary transparency report, CSC was funding **650+ Chinese PhD/postdoc scholars per year in the UK** as of a few years ago, with Cambridge taking a significant share of those.[70] [71] The Cambridge Trust arrangement ensures that CSC scholars receive full funding packages. Cambridge's program has no restriction on field (priority subjects may be set by CSC each year, but generally all disciplines are included).[72] To apply, candidates must gain admission to Cambridge and also apply to CSC; final selection is made by the CSC in coordination with Cambridge.[73]

- **University of Oxford:** Oxford likewise offers the **China Scholarship Council–University of Oxford Scholarships**. The University's scholarship listings show this as a distinct program, which for the 2025–26 academic year provides **up to 20 full scholarships** for Chinese students.[74] [75] Each scholarship covers *"100% of course fees, a grant for living costs (at least £19,237), and one return flight from China to the UK."*.[76] Awards are given for the full duration of the student's fee liability (e.g. up to 3-4 years for a DPhil/PhD). The funding is jointly provided by Oxford and CSC. Typically, CSC will cover the living allowance and airfare, while Oxford (through its scholarships or departmental funds) covers the tuition/college fees – effectively a mirror of the model used elsewhere. The **eligibility** is for citizens of the PRC who will return to China after the degree, and the program is available for most full-time Masters and DPhil courses at Oxford.[77] Oxford's China Office and student newspaper have noted that the program doubled in size around 2022 (from 10 to 20 awards per year),[78] indicating a renewal of the MOU that expanded the cohort. Indeed, Notre Dame University's news site reported a virtual signing with CSC in 2022 that "**doubled the number of doctoral students supported**" by CSC at Oxford (and Notre Dame)[79], likely referencing this scale-up.

Both Oxford and Cambridge require CSC applicants to meet the university's admission criteria and then be selected by CSC. These scholarships have attracted attention because of the CSC's conditions (such as requiring a pledge of loyalty to the Chinese government). For instance, Oxford's student newspaper *Cherwell* reported in Dec 2024 on Oxford's continued participation in the CSC scheme, noting that it *"funds up to 20"* students and quoting the requirement that *"applicants must support the leadership of the*

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68 See https://www.cambridgetrust.org/scholarships/csc-cambridge-scholarship
69 Ibid.
70 See https://www.ecns.cn/news/society/2018-06-07/detail-ifyuyvzv3224743.shtml
71 See https://ukctransparency.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/China-Scholarship-Council-Rules-translation-and-notes-1.pdf
72 See https://www.cambridgetrust.org/scholarships/csc-cambridge-scholarship
73 Ibid.
74 See https://www.ox.ac.uk/admissions/graduate/fees-and-funding/fees-funding-and-scholarship-search/china-scholarship-council-university-oxford-scholarships
75 See https://www.cherwell.org/2024/12/03/oxford-university-continues-to-offer-scholarship-that-requires-support-of-the-leadership-of-the-communist-party-of-china/
76 See https://www.ox.ac.uk/admissions/graduate/fees-and-funding/fees-funding-and-scholarship-search/china-scholarship-council-university-oxford-scholarships
77 See https://www.mastersportal.com/scholarships/7354/china-scholarship-council-university-of-oxford-scholarships.html
78 See https://global.nd.edu/news-stories/news/notre-dame-international-hosts-virtual-week-in-china-creates-and-renews-student-and-research-opportunities/
79 Ibid.

Communist Party of China and love the motherland" as part of the CSC's application conditions.[80] Despite some controversy, the program remains in place as of 2025.

Aside from Oxbridge, many other UK universities have CSC MOUs. These include the **Imperial College London**, **University of Edinburgh**, **University of Southampton** (which advertises CSC scholarships for PhDs)[81], **University of Glasgow**, **University of Warwick**, and others. In these cases, the common pattern is: the university waives tuition or provides a scholarship, while CSC provides living costs for up to 4 years. A translated statistic indicates *"the CSC funds at least 650 Chinese PhD and postdoc students per year in the UK"*,[82] [83] underscoring how widespread these partnerships are across British universities.

In summary, **Cambridge and Oxford** exemplify the UK model: Cambridge Trust–CSC scholarships for both PhD and Master's students in any field,[84] and Oxford–CSC scholarships (about 20 per year) covering full costs.[85] These partnerships have been renewed and continue strong into 2025, providing significant opportunities for Chinese scholars in the UK, while giving UK institutions access to a pipeline of funded graduate students.

Enforcement and Compliance Mechanisms

Enforcement of CSC obligations is largely handled on the Chinese side, with limited direct involvement from host universities. All CSC-funded students are required to sign an agreement (often called the *"State-Sponsored Study Abroad Agreement"*) with the CSC before departure.[86] This contract includes several compliance requirements:

- **Regular Reporting:** Students must report their academic progress at set intervals to the Chinese authorities (usually via the education office of the Chinese embassy/consulate in the host country).[87] In practice, many CSC scholars must submit progress reports or have their supervisor sign off each semester on their performance. For example, a U.S. professor might be asked to sign a form confirming the student's study progress, which the student then submits to the embassy. These reports are generally academic in nature (grades, research progress), but they form part of the oversight by CSC. The host institution typically does not object to this reporting, but **may not realize** that the signed reports are being sent to Chinese officials.
- **Return and Service Requirement:** A core condition is that the student **must return to China for at least two years** after completing their funded program.[88] This is known as the "2-year home service" requirement. It's intended to ensure the student contributes their skills to China and is non-negotiable per CSC/MOE rules. If a scholar fails to return on time (or at all), it is considered a breach of their scholarship contract. The agreement also stipulates that the student should not do anything to discredit China and should uphold certain ideological standards while abroad[89] (for instance, refraining from political activities deemed harmful).

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80 See https://www.cherwell.org/2024/12/03/oxford-university-continues-to-offer-scholarship-that-requires-support-of-the-leadership-of-the-communist-party-of-china/
81 See https://www.southampton.ac.uk/study/fees-funding/scholarships/partnerships-china-scholarship-council
82 See https://ukctransparency.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/China-Scholarship-Council-Rules-translation-and-notes-1.pdf
83 See https://www.ecns.cn/news/society/2018-06-07/detail-ifyuyvzv3224743.shtml
84 See https://www.cambridgetrust.org/scholarships/csc-cambridge-scholarship
85 See https://www.ox.ac.uk/admissions/graduate/fees-and-funding/fees-funding-and-scholarship-search/china-scholarship-council-university-oxford-scholarships
86 See https://cset.georgetown.edu/publication/china-scholarship-council-subsidized-study-abroad-agreement/
87 Ibid.
88 Ibid.
89 See https://www.cherwell.org/2024/12/03/oxford-university-continues-to-offer-scholarship-that-requires-support-of-the-leadership-of-the-communist-party-of-china/

- **Guarantors and Penalties:** CSC requires each scholar to designate two guarantors (often parents or other officials) who co-sign the contract. If the student violates the terms – for example, does not return to China – **financial penalties** kick in.[90] The student and guarantors can be held liable to repay the full scholarship amount plus a penalty (usually an additional percentage. For instance, returning a few months late might incur a 20% penalty on top of repayment, whereas not returning at all (a "full breach") could require 100% repayment plus 30% penalty. This threat of financial "ruin" is meant to enforce compliance. It essentially places the burden on the student (and their family/guarantors) to ensure the student comes back.
- **Ideological Monitoring:** As noted, before departure students sign commitments to abide by Chinese laws and demonstrate loyalty. Chinese embassies often continue **political supervision** while the student is abroad. Party-member students have to give ideological updates to party organizations even during overseas study. While this is not an "enforcement" the host university partakes in, it is a compliance mechanism within the Chinese system.

Research Security Risks in the United States and Notable Cases of CSC-Funded Scholars Tied to the PLA

Over the past five years, CSC-funded scholars have played active roles in U.S.-based research projects supported by federal agencies such as the National Science Foundation (NSF), the Department of Energy (DOE), the National Institutes of Health (NIH), and even the Department of Defense (DoD). These scholars, selected in part for their political loyalty to the CCP, are often embedded in sensitive scientific research programs that carry dual-use or national security implications. Their contributions—while academically valuable—raise concerns about intellectual property leakage, dual-funding transparency, and potential downstream use by Chinese military or defense-affiliated institutions.

At the University of California, Irvine, CSC scholars co-authored research on advanced wireless communication technologies, funded simultaneously by the NSF and Chinese sources including the CSC and the National Natural Science Foundation of China.[91] Similar dual-funded research occurred at UC Davis, where scholars contributed to NSF-supported work on post-disaster recovery in optical networks.[92] In another case, UC Irvine collaborated with Peking University on fusion plasma modeling—jointly supported by the DOE and Chinese institutions—with CSC-funded researcher Kaijie Wang as a contributor.[93] These examples illustrate how Chinese government-sponsored scholars participate directly in federally funded U.S. science.

Other research areas involving CSC-supported scholars include agricultural genomics (UC Davis)[94], entomology (UC Riverside)[95], molecular dynamics (Dartmouth and Temple University)[96], and post-ischemic cardiac injury (Temple University).[97] All of these projects received NIH or NSF funding and involved CSC participants with affiliations to both U.S. and Chinese universities. In many cases, the Chinese institution was itself affiliated with the CCP or a military-linked research body. For instance, Yunling Deng, a CSC recipient, conducted NSF-funded research at Dartmouth while collaborating with

90 See https://cset.georgetown.edu/publication/china-scholarship-council-subsidized-study-abroad-agreement/
91 See https://doi.org/10.1109/twc.2024.3393412
92 See https://doi.org/10.23919/ondm61578.2024.10582610
93 See https://iopscience.iop.org/article/10.1088/1361-6587/aceb88/ampdf
94 See https://peerj.com/articles/17323
95 See https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC11745349
96 See https://doi.org/10.1021/acs.jpcb.4c00625
97 See https://doi.org/10.1016/j.redox.2023.102909

Temple University on biomolecular simulations.[98] At the University of Tennessee, CSC scholars participated in materials science research backed by the Army Research Office and NSF, raising clear dual-use concerns.[99]

Some cases intersect directly with military or defense research. A CSC-funded scholar, Jun Wang, contributed to DARPA- and Air Force Research Laboratory–funded artificial intelligence research at Purdue University, reflecting PLA-adjacent exposure to sensitive U.S. programs.[100] [101] Similarly, Chang Liu—a CSC awardee who previously studied at Johns Hopkins and later at UC Berkeley—contributed to research supported by the Office of Naval Research (ONR) at the University of Notre Dame, focused on complex aerospace mechanics.[102]

These cases highlight the growing risk that CSC-sponsored individuals may serve as conduits between U.S. federally funded research and Chinese state-linked institutions, including the People's Liberation Army (PLA). In many cases, these scholars maintain formal or informal affiliations with Chinese research bodies that are either overseen by the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology or directly managed by the PLA. While host universities may see these students as high-performing international collaborators, their funding source, selection process, and long-term obligations to the Chinese state raise urgent concerns about research security and technology transfer.

- **Tang Juan (UC Davis, 2019–2020)** – A visiting cancer researcher at University of California, Davis, Tang arrived in Dec 2019 on a CSC scholarship. She was later revealed to be a uniformed officer in the PLA Air Force, affiliated with the Air Force Military Medical University (Fourth Military Medical University) in Xi'an. Tang was charged in 2020 with visa fraud for concealing her military service (photos were found of her in PLA uniform), and she temporarily sought refuge in China's San Francisco consulate to avoid arrest. UC Davis confirmed her research was funded by the CSC (in partnership with China's Xijing Hospital).[103] [104] [105]
- **Song Chen (Stanford University, 2018–2020)** – Also known as Chen Song, she was a visiting scholar in neurology at Stanford, supported for one year by a CSC scholarship starting in late 2018. In reality, Song was an active-duty member of the PLA, serving as a physician at the PLA Air Force General Hospital in Beijing (she had claimed her employer was a civilian hospital as a cover). FBI investigators found that she had co-authored scientific papers listing her true affiliation with PLA-linked institutions (e.g. the Air Force General Hospital and Fourth Military Medical University)[106]. In July 2020 she was arrested and charged with visa fraud and destroying

98 See https://doi.org/10.1021/acs.jpcb.4c00625
99 See https://dtic.dimensions.ai/details/publication/pub.1182119892
100 See https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0167865524000709?via%3Dihub
101 See https://engineering.purdue.edu/SEMAFOR
102 See https://arc.aiaa.org/doi/epdf/10.2514/1.J061706
103 See https://www.latimes.com/california/story/2020-07-23/uc-davis-researcher-accused-of-hiding-ties-to-chinese-military-is-hiding-in-consulate-u-s-says#:~:text=Andy%20Fell%2C%20a%20spokesman%20for,Hospital%20in%20China%2C%E2%80%9D%20Fell%20said
104 See https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/researchers-charged-visa-fraud-after-lying-about-their-work-china-s-people-s-liberation-army#:~:text=PLA,the%20autopsy%20on%20the%20former
105 See https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2020/07/28/fbi-arrests-scholars-accused-lying-about-chinese-military-ties#:~:text=UC%20Davis%20said%20in%20a,at%20the%20end%20of%20June
106 See https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/researchers-charged-visa-fraud-after-lying-about-their-work-china-s-people-s-liberation-army

evidence, accused of lying about her military status to gain access to Stanford's lab. The charges were later dropped in 2021, after she had spent months under restrictions.[107] [108] [109]

- **Wang Xin (UC San Francisco, 2019–2020)** – Wang was a visiting scholar in medicine at UCSF who entered the U.S. in early 2019 on a J-1 visa **funded by the CSC** (FBI arrests scholars accused of lying about Chinese military ties He was in fact a **PLA officer (ranked Major)** still employed by a military research lab in China). Upon questioning, Wang admitted his military supervisor in China had instructed him to **observe and copy the layout and research of the UCSF lab** so it could be replicated back home. He also admitted to **emailing UCSF research data to his PLA lab** and intended to bring data back to China (FBI arrests scholars accused of lying about Chinese military ties. Wang was arrested in June 2020 and charged with visa fraud for hiding his ongoing PLA. [110] [111]

- **Zhao Kaikai (Indiana University, 2018–2020)** – Zhao was a Ph.D. student in machine learning at Indiana University Bloomington, who came to the U.S. in 2018 (F-1 visa). He had previously attended the Aviation University of Air Force (AUAF) – a Chinese military academy – and the National University of Defense Technology (NUDT) in China, meaning he was essentially a PLA-affiliated student. On his U.S. visa application, Zhao denied any military service, but evidence later showed he **continued working on Chinese military projects while studying in the U.S.** (FBI arrests scholars accused of lying about Chinese military ties). He co-authored publications on **military radar technology** and even **filed a Chinese patent for radar technology** during his doctoral studies. Investigators also found a photo of him in a PLA Air Force uniform. Zhao was arrested in July 2020 for visa fraud, with U.S. authorities noting that his research and patent work on radar had direct defense applications (FBI arrests scholars accused of lying about Chinese military ties).[112] [113]

- **Guan Lei (UCLA, 2018–2020)** – Guan was a visiting researcher in mathematics at UCLA, focusing on machine-learning algorithms. He had graduated from NUDT in China – a top military-run university under the PLA. Like many NUDT scholars abroad, he likely came with Chinese government scholarship support (NUDT doctoral students are known to bring their own CSC funding to overseas labs). In 2020, Guan became the subject of an FBI investigation on suspicion that he was transferring sensitive U.S. research to Chinese military contacts). Agents alleged that he had shared **"sensitive software or technical data" with high-ranking PLA officials**. In August 2020, as the investigation closed in, Guan **destroyed a computer hard drive** (caught by agents throwing it in a dumpster) and attempted to fly back to China). He was arrested and charged with destruction of evidence, and investigators noted his links to NUDT and possible PLA affiliations (though he denied being an active military officer). *(This case illustrates how even when*

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107 See https://stanforddaily.com/2020/07/20/visiting-scholar-at-stanford-charged-with-visa-fraud/#:~:text=According%20to%20Song%E2%80%99s%20interview%2C%20a,as%20a%20source%20of%20funding
108 See https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/researchers-charged-visa-fraud-after-lying-about-their-work-china-s-people-s-liberation-army#:~:text=PLA,the%20autopsy%20on%20the%20former
109 See https://www.reuters.com/world/us/us-seeks-dismiss-charges-visa-fraud-cases-chinese-researchers-2021-07-23/#:~:text=John%20Hemann%2C%20a%20lawyer%20for,has%20done%20the%20right%20thing
110 See https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/researchers-charged-visa-fraud-after-lying-about-their-work-china-s-people-s-liberation-army
111 See https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2020/07/28/fbi-arrests-scholars-accused-lying-about-chinese-military-ties
112 See https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2020/07/28/fbi-arrests-scholars-accused-lying-about-chinese-military-ties
113 See https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/researchers-charged-visa-fraud-after-lying-about-their-work-china-s-people-s-liberation-army

not officially identified as active military, CSC-sponsored researchers from defense universities may still channel valuable know-how to the PLA.) [114] [115]

Broader Context and Impact

These cases underscore how China's **Military-Civil Fusion** strategy can leverage academic exchanges. CSC scholarships require recipients to return to China and serve national development, and in some instances this has translated into **direct support for defense projects**. Scholars like Tang and Song obtained positions in sensitive U.S. labs while effectively on **PLA assignment**, and others like Zhao and Guan contributed to Chinese military technology through research collaborations and patents developed during their studies abroad. A Hoover Institution analysis found **at least 254 research papers** in recent years co-authored by scientists from U.S. universities and China's key PLA-affiliated institutions. This suggests that beyond the individual examples above, there is a pattern of knowledge transfer – sometimes inadvertent – from U.S. academic research into China's defense sector. U.S. universities and authorities have become increasingly alert to these risks, leading to visa restrictions and the termination of programs (for instance, the University of North Texas ended its CSC scholar hosting in 2020 amid security concerns). Each of the publicly documented cases above highlights a facet of the broader issue: **CSC-funded education and research in the U.S. feeding into China's military modernization**, whether through formal employment on return or via collaborative research outcomes.[116] [117]

Policy Recommendations

To safeguard national research integrity and protect against undue foreign influence, particularly from the CSC and its embedded mechanisms of state control, the following policy actions are recommended:

1. **Mandatory Disclosure of Foreign Funding Sources**
   Require all U.S. universities and federal grant recipients to publicly disclose the foreign funding sources of their students, visiting scholars, and research collaborators—including CSC scholarships—within project reports and conflict-of-interest disclosures.
2. **Restrict Access to Federally Funded Research**
   Prohibit CSC-sponsored scholars from participating in research funded by the DoD, DOE, NIH, NSF, and other federal agencies, particularly in dual-use or emerging technology areas.
3. **Terminate or Review University MOUs with CSC**
   Strongly encourage U.S. universities to suspend MOUs with the CSC. At minimum,

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114 See https://www.latimes.com/california/story/2020-08-28/ucla-researcher-accused-of-destroying-evidence-latest-arrest-in-crackdown-on-visiting-chinese-scientists
115 See https://delta.tudelft.nl/en/article/chinese-scientists-tu-delft-target-military-knowledge
116 See https://www.wsj.com/articles/report-sheds-light-on-chinas-use-of-military-linked-researchers-11596092462#:~:text=WASHINGTON%E2%80%94Researchers%20in%20the%20U,by%20Stanford%20University%E2%80%99s%20Hoover%20Institution
117 See https://thepienews.com/china-scholarship-council-prestigious-precarious/#:~:text=It%E2%80%99s%20not%20the%20first%20time,the%20middle%20of%20a%20pandemic

institutions should conduct national security reviews of existing agreements, in coordination with the Departments of Education, State, and Homeland Security, to assess the risk of technology transfer and ideological influence.

4. **Develop a CSC Watchlist and Risk Screening Tools**
   Establish a federal database or watchlist of known CSC-affiliated scholars, institutions, and partner universities. Make this resource available to university compliance offices and federal grant administrators to enable screening of applications and collaborations for potential risk.
5. **Enforce Visa Transparency and Military Affiliation Checks**
   Require all visiting scholars and graduate students from China to disclose past or present affiliations with the PLA or defense-linked universities (e.g., NUDT, AVIC institutions) as a condition of visa approval. Enhanced vetting should be applied to CSC-funded scholars given documented concealment cases.
6. **Condition Federal Funding on Research Security Compliance**
   Tie eligibility for federal research funding to demonstrated research security policies. Institutions that knowingly host CSC scholars in federally funded projects without disclosure, or maintain CSC partnerships that undermine U.S. research integrity, should be subject to funding restrictions or penalties.
7. **Expand Whistleblower Protections and Oversight Mechanisms**
   Increase protections and reporting mechanisms for whistleblowers in academia who raise concerns about foreign government influence, including CSC involvement. Establish secure channels for reporting violations of federal funding rules or undisclosed dual affiliations.
8. **Coordinate Internationally with Allied Research Partners**
   Work with partners in the Five Eyes, NATO, and Indo-Pacific alliances to align restrictions on CSC-funded scholars, share intelligence on PLA-linked academic programs, and discourage tuition-waiver arrangements that subsidize Chinese state-directed education pipelines.

These measures aim to reduce systemic vulnerabilities, protect intellectual property, and ensure U.S. research ecosystems remain open, secure, and free from coercive foreign influence.